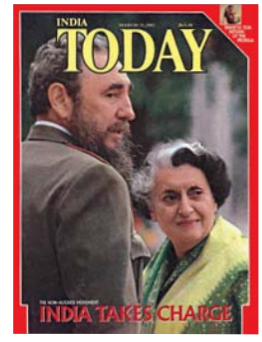
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

For a year, beginning in December, India will take its place in the centre stage of international affairs. It assumes the rotating presidency of the G20, one of the most influential groupings of world powers, with the bandwidth to steer and even alter the course of geopolitical interactions. It is a role that befits it—a kind of neutral referee, speaking from a position of authority, but also with a uniquely non-partisan voice that every nation can listen to. Coincidentally, India also assumes the presidency of the all-powerful UN Security Council in December for a month and will chair the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO), the world's largest regional forum, till September 2023. Suddenly, it feels like India's moment under the sun. The G20 is the prize seat at the high table. Here, New Delhi has the occasion to bring its statesmanship and independently crafted position on the global stage into the thorny area of multilateral negotiations.

From now to late 2023, India will host upwards of 200 global meetings in 56 locations across its map—from Srinagar to Thiruvananthapuram, from the Rann of Kutch to Kohima, covering all states and Union territories. The topics will span the gamut of issues that bedevil nations—trade and economy, international taxation, financial inclusion, the digital economy, tourism, health, food security and agriculture, energy and climate change. These are organised into two primary tracks: the Finance track, consisting of eight work streams, will have 40 meetings; the other, the Sherpa Track, consisting of 13 working groups, will have 60 sessions. Then there will be 15 high-level ministerial meetings, including one of foreign and finance ministers. Besides 12 engagement groups for non-governmental entities engaged with business, science, gender issues and—this is India's addition—start-ups. These groups will have over 50 meetings, 25 seminars and workshops. A new-look Pragati Maidan in Delhi will host the main summit in September 2023—expect 43 heads of states, governments and international organisations, besides special invitees. Alongside await a treat of Festivals of India at Ahmedabad, Konark, Surajkund, Kohima and Khajuraho—the *mela* ground excitement that we are naturally good at.



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What does all this dizzying activity add up to? That has to be understood in terms of the opportunities and challenges it presents. The G20 is a unique platform. Not a decision-making, executive body with the kind of remit that multilateral agencies like the UN, IMF, World Bank or the WHO have, but one that offers a unique space for consensus-building among the comity of nations, whose word then often carries over to the ones that lay down the rules.

Last July, for instance, the G20, along with the OECD, evolved the idea of a minimum corporate tax of 15 per cent for MNCs, which were otherwise prone to evading giving anything up on their profits by operating from tax havens. In 2018, it was on the margins of the summit in Buenos Aires that the North American free trade agreement CUSMO came about. Before that, the global Financial Stability Board (FSB) of April 2009 and the Basel III framework of July 2009 that introduced stricter capital and liquidity requirements for banks were fruits of the G20 summitry. Even at the geopolitical level, the Joe Biden-Xi Jinping interaction in Bali last month helped bring a touch of equanimity to relations that had otherwise assumed a hard edge of hostility. Therefore, the G20 is no mere talking shop—its very nature allows it to surmount partisan interests and reach for multilateral coordination.

The formation of the G20 in 1999 speaks to how the world economy has been evolving in recent decades. It was the Asian financial crisis that triggered its birth, initially as a forum for finance ministers that included these countries. Former US president George W. Bush scaled it up in 2008 to the political leadership level after the global meltdown—lending it a more well-rounded geopolitical dimension. Now, this grouping of developed and developing nations represents 85 per cent of the world's GDP, 75 per cent of international trade, and 60 per cent of the planet's population—numbering some 4.6 billion people. And India will be the master of ceremonies as the members of this global club confer.

To understand why this is a vital position and not just a ceremonial role, look only at the state of the world. Turmoil surrounds us on all fronts. The post-pandemic scenario is still tipping towards what everybody predicts will be a global recession next year. Over 70 countries, including our neighbours Sri Lanka and Pakistan, are facing crippling national debt levels. The Russia-Ukraine conflict has only exacerbated the global supply chain disruptions caused by Covid-19. From wheat exports to the energy crisis that Europe stares at to the new urgency that marks climate change discussions, there's a universal sense that 2022-23 will be a critical passage for the planet. This is the stage that India enters, not just as an impresario but as a country with its unique footprint in, and sway over, world affairs.

A rising power, it is also one that still carries the gene of Global South solidarity. Thus, we can be an honest broker talking about solutions. Western critics can see New Delhi's old friendship with Moscow as posing a conflict of interest. Still, it also invests India with exceptional leverage as a party that can talk to both sides and arrive at a consensus to end the war. Outcomes will be critical as India's G20 presidency hits its stride—it aims to push for a financial toolkit that can reform the terms of multilateral lending, means to enable climate-friendly energy transitions, and carry forward the work on rationalising global corporate tax regimes. All this is intended to ensure that poorer nations secure a better deal.

Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa brings his vast expertise in international affairs to unpack this complex but infinitely fascinating picture for our cover story this week. How Prime Minister Modi uses the next year to legitimise India's quest for a diplomatic space in global affairs while also showcasing India in all its myriad colours will be fascinating. India's theme—'One Earth, One Family, One Future'—reflects the desire to steer this synergy. Streamlining our efforts—rather than reversing protectionism —is the only way out for humanity.

(Aroon Purie)